

TASTING AT HOME

Professional tasting is not done for enjoyment, but you can have fun exploring the flavors and characteristics of different teas in your own home. With an open mind, a tasting can allow you to discover new teas.

YOU WILL NEED

1 tsp tea leaves per person, such as green, oolong, and black, or a “flight” of 3 types of tea, for example, Darjeeling

tea pot, or tea cup with a lid or small saucer to cover
almonds or pumpkin seeds, to neutralize your palate between tastings

1 Examine the dry leaf and note its color, shape, size, and fragrance. Place 1 tsp tea leaves for each person into your tea pot or cup. Add $\frac{3}{4}$ cup water per tsp tea leaf, at the appropriate temperature, cover with the lid or small saucer, and leave to steep. Refer to pages 42–47 for guidance on the infusion time for each type of tea.

2 Remove the lid and put your ear to the leaves. Notice the slight popping sound of the leaves unfurling.

3 The aroma should begin to waft as the water touches the leaves. To get a sense of how the tea will taste, lift the lid and hold it to your nose once the infusion is ready. Volatile oils will have started to evaporate from the infusion.

4 Strain the tea into tasting cups. Then examine the wet leaves carefully, and take in the aroma.

5 Notice the color of the tea. Inhale, then take a quick slurp to draw the flavors to all the taste receptors around the tongue. Notice how the tea feels; this is the “mouthfeel” of the tea. Some key flavors are shown on the flavor wheel (see pp50–51) to help you describe the tea.

Do not wear fragrance when tasting tea, as it will interfere with your sense of smell when trying to isolate aromas.

